

"Holiday Kidney Syndrome"

Surviving Fiestas, Reunions & the Holidays with CKD

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Every December and every fiesta season, kidney patients are rushed to emergency rooms — and some die — because of food, drinks, and skipped dialysis sessions at celebrations. We call this pattern "Holiday Kidney Syndrome." It is preventable. This pocket companion is the plan: what to eat, what to skip, how to protect your dialysis schedule, and when to go to the ER.

The one-sentence version

Enjoy the party — but plan your plate, count your fruit, budget your fluid, take your medicines, and never, ever stretch your dialysis gap for a celebration.

The Most Dangerous 72 Hours of the Year

THE LONG GAP RISK

Skipping or delaying dialysis during the holidays can be dangerous.

Extra food, drinks, and busy schedules can lead to fluid overload, high potassium, and other life-threatening complications.



Don't let a few missed sessions become an emergency.

WHAT CAN HAPPEN WITH LONG GAPS?



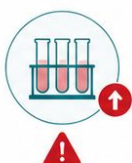
FLUID OVERLOAD

Leads to swelling, shortness of breath, and high blood pressure.



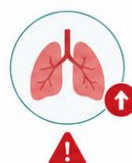
HIGH POTASSIUM

Can cause dangerous irregular heartbeats or even cardiac arrest.



TOXIN BUILD-UP

Waste in the blood can cause nausea, weakness, and confusion.



BREATHING PROBLEMS

Too much fluid in the lungs can make it hard to breathe and may require hospital care.



HOSPITALIZATION RISK

Skipping sessions can turn the holidays into a medical emergency.



PLAN AHEAD. STAY SAFE.

- ✓ Keep your dialysis schedule — even during the holidays.
- ✓ If you must travel, coordinate with your dialysis center in advance.
- ✓ Follow your fluid and diet plan.
- ✓ When in doubt, **don't miss. Call.**



Your best gift this season?

Sticking to your dialysis plan.

It keeps you strong for the moments that matter.



Every patient is different. Talk to your nephrologist about your holiday dialysis plan.



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- **The long gap** — on a 3x/week schedule you already have one 2-day gap. Large studies (32,065 patients) show the day after it is the deadliest day of the week: +23% deaths, +77% heart-failure admissions, +90% dangerous heart rhythms.
- **Holidays stretch the gap** — a closed unit or a "moved" session turns 2 days into 3-4 — and the feast lands exactly when your body has no way to remove potassium and fluid.
- **No cheat days in kidney failure** — what you eat waits in your blood until your next session. There are only portions you planned and portions you will regret.

The two golden rules

1) Move holiday sessions EARLIER, never later — never let your gap exceed about 72 hours. 2) Schedule celebrations right AFTER dialysis, when potassium and fluid are at their weekly lowest.

Party Food: Hidden Risks

PARTY FOOD, HIDDEN RISKS

Tasty favorites that can stress your kidneys.

Holiday dishes are often high in sodium, phosphorus, and potassium. Too much can lead to fluid overload and other serious problems.



COMMON PARTY FOODS TO WATCH



HAM & PROCESSED MEATS

Very high in sodium — can cause thirst, swelling, and high blood pressure.



SODIUM



FRUIT SALAD

Often high in potassium and sugar — risky for kidneys and blood sugar.



POTASSIUM



PANCIT & NOODLES

High in sodium and phosphorus from sauces and seasonings.



SODIUM



FRIED FOODS

High in phosphorus additives and unhealthy fats.



PHOSPHORUS



SOFT DRINKS

High in phosphorus and sugar — adds empty calories and fluid retention.



PHOSPHORUS



SMARTER SWAPS, SAFER CHOICES



Choose fresh meats over ham or processed meats.



Pick lower-potassium fruits in small portions (apple, grapes, pineapple).



Enjoy pancit in smaller servings. Ask for less sauce.



Choose grilled, baked, or air-fried options.



Water is best. Skip the soft drinks.



PARTY SURVIVAL TIPS



Use a small plate. Control your portions.



Mind the time. Don't go too long between dialysis and feasts.



Stay hydrated within your fluid allowance.



Know your limits. It's okay to say no or enjoy less.



Every patient is different. Talk to your nephrologist or dietitian about the right diet plan for you.



Enjoy the celebration. Protect your kidneys. Small choices. Big difference.

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- **Plate strategy** — half plate rice + safest dishes, then TWO small favorites. One plate, one pass — walang balikan.
- **These are general rules** — your own dietitian's advice — based on your latest potassium and phosphorus levels — always overrides the lists on the next page.

Filipino Celebration Dishes — Enjoy, Taste, or Skip

SAFER CHOICES — enjoy in normal portions

- **Steamed white rice** — your safest base; fill from here first.
- **Inihaw na isda / grilled fish** — skip heavy marinades and toyo-calamansi dips.
- **Grilled or roasted chicken, skin removed** — plain inasal-style without the basting sauce.
- **Lumpiang sariwa (fresh)** — go light on the sweet garlic sauce and skip the crushed peanuts.
- **Puto, kutsinta (plain, no cheese topping)** — rice-based kakanin are among the safer desserts.
- **Pancit bihon (small plate)** — ask the cook to go easy on soy sauce; one fist-sized serving.

SMALL TASTE ONLY — 2-3 bites, once

- **Lechon** — small piece of lean meat; leave the skin and the liver sauce.
- **Christmas ham (hamonado) & keso de bola** — very high salt and phosphorus; a thin slice of each at most.
- **Filipino spaghetti, embutido, hotdogs** — processed meat and cheese mean sodium plus hidden phosphorus.
- **Fruit salad / buko salad** — condensed milk + cream + fruits = potassium, phosphorus, sugar, and fluid in one cup. Two spoonfuls, not a bowl.
- **Bibingka & puto bumbong** — the rice cake itself is fine; the salted egg, cheese, and coconut on top are the problem. Ask for it plain.
- **Leche flan** — egg yolks and condensed milk carry phosphorus; one thin slice.

SKIP THESE — the highest-risk party dishes

- **Dinuguan** — blood is one of the most concentrated potassium and phosphorus sources on any table.
- **Kare-kare with bagoong** — peanut sauce is potassium-rich; bagoong is one of the saltiest foods that exists.
- **Sisig, chicharon, crispy pata** — organ meats, deep-fried skin: phosphorus, sodium, and fat together.
- **Itlog na maalat (salted egg)** — extreme sodium in a small package.
- **Salty chips, mixed nuts, cornick** — the "harmless" grazing bowls beside the karaoke — potassium + sodium + phosphorus you never count.
- **Gravy, instant sauces, all-day sabaw pots (bulalo, nilaga)** — salt plus fluid; broth counts entirely against your fluid limit.

The Fruit Trap: "It's Just Fruit" Is How It Starts

THE FRUIT TRAP

Delicious, but easy to overdo.

Many holiday fruits are high in potassium.
Too much can be dangerous for kidney patients.



RAMBUTAN
High Potassium ↑



LANGSAT / LANZONES
High Potassium ↑

ENJOY IN MODERATION

Smaller portions, less often.



SMALL PORTIONS

Stick to small servings.



LESS OFTEN

Not every day, especially during the holidays.



KNOW YOUR LIMIT

Follow your diet plan and lab results.



WHY IT MATTERS

High potassium can cause:

- Irregular heartbeat
- Muscle weakness
- Life-threatening complications



FRUIT SALAD
High Potassium ↑



Love fruits. Protect your kidneys.
Balance is the best gift you can give yourself and your family.



Every patient is different.
Ask your nephrologist or dietitian what fruits are right for you.



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- **The rule** — ONE fruit, ONE serving, ONCE that day — decided before you sit down.
- **Why you lose count** — each piece is small, so twenty rambutan over an afternoon of chatting is a massive potassium load — landing on a stretched holiday gap with nowhere to go except your heart's electrical system.

NEVER: star fruit (balimbing) — at any amount

Star fruit contains a toxin (caramboxin) that failing kidneys cannot remove. Even one fruit or one glass of juice can cause unstoppable hiccups, confusion, seizures, and death. Hiccups that will not stop after eating balimbing = go to the ER immediately and say what you ate.

Holiday Fruits — Risk and the Rule

Holiday fruit	Potassium risk	The trap / the rule
Balimbing (star fruit)	NEVER	Toxic to kidney patients regardless of potassium — see the warning on the previous page.
Durian	Very high	One seed-section is already a big load; at a reunion nobody eats just one.
Rambutan	High in quantity	Small per piece — but who eats one? Count out 5 pieces, walk away from the bowl.
Lanzones	High in quantity	Same trap as rambutan — eaten by the handful. 5-8 pieces maximum, once.
Langka (jackfruit)	High	In fruit salad, turon, and halo-halo too — it hides in desserts.
Saging (banana)	High	Includes banana cue and turon at street parties.
Melon & pakwan (watermelon)	High	High potassium AND counts as fluid — a double hit for dialysis patients.
Chico, atis, dalandan / orange	High	Holiday-season favorites; treat like rambutan — strict small portion.
Mangga (mango)	Moderate	Half of one small ripe mango is a reasonable single serving.
Ubas (grapes)	Moderate	The New Year "12 grapes" tradition is fine — 12 grapes, not 12 bunches.
Pinya (pineapple)	Lower	One of the better fruit choices at a party, in one normal slice.
Mansanas (apple), peras (pear)	Lower	The classic "safe" fruits — a whole small apple is fine for most patients.

Never graze from the fruit bowl

Decide your portion before you sit down, put it on a small plate, and move away from the bandehado. Decisions made in advance survive temptation; decisions made at the table do not.

The Fiesta Plate

THE FIESTA PLATE

Enjoy the celebration. Protect your kidneys.

You can enjoy your favorite holiday foods with a little planning and smart choices.



The Goal:
Balance and moderation.
Small choices today, better tomorrows.

BUILD A KIDNEY-FRIENDLY FIESTA PLATE



1. START WITH SMALL PORTIONS

Begin with a little. You can always choose less.



2. CHOOSE KIDNEY-FRIENDLY PROTEINS

Go for grilled fish, chicken without skin, or lean meats. Avoid processed meats.



3. ADD VEGETABLES

Choose low-potassium veggies like sayote, pechay, baguio beans, or cabbage.



4. ENJOY FRUITS IN MODERATION

Pick lower-potassium fruits and small portions. Avoid fruit salad with lots of syrup.



5. WATCH YOUR DRINKS

Water is best. Limit softdrinks, juices, alcohol, and sweetened beverages.



SMART REMINDERS

- ✓ Stick to your diet and fluid plan.
- ✓ Mind your salt, sauces, and seasonings.
- ✓ Avoid "extra" helpings.
- ✓ Take your medications as prescribed.
- ✓ Enjoy the company, not just the food!

You're in control. **One choice at a time.**



Celebrate with love.
Choose with care.
Protect your kidneys. Enjoy life.



Every patient is different.
Talk to your nephrologist or dietitian for a meal plan that's right for you.



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- **The goal** — balance and moderation — small choices today, better tomorrows.
- **Two favorites enjoyed slowly** — beat ten favorites regretted at the ER. The full 8-step plan is on the next page.

How to Build Your Fiesta Plate — 8 Steps

- 1 Don't arrive starving.**
Eat a normal, kidney-safe meal or snack before you leave the house. Hunger at a buffet defeats every plan ever made.
- 2 Bring your binders.**
If you are prescribed phosphate binders, they belong in your pocket at every party and must be taken WITH the party meal — that is exactly the meal they exist for.
- 3 Survey the whole table before touching anything.**
Walk the length of the buffet first. Decide your two favorites. A plan made with your eyes is stronger than one made with your stomach.
- 4 Half your plate: rice and the safest dishes.**
Then add your TWO chosen favorites in small portions. Two favorites enjoyed slowly beat ten favorites regretted at the ER.
- 5 One plate, one pass — walang balikan.**
Fill it once, then leave the buffet zone. Sit far from the food table and the grazing bowls.
- 6 Decide fruit and drink before the party.**
One fruit, one serving. One small cup, refilled within your budget. Decisions made in advance survive temptation; decisions made at the table do not.
- 7 Have your "no, thank you" script ready.**
Filipino hosts insist — it is love. Try: "Masarap talaga, pero bawal sa dialysis ko. Tikim na lang ako para hindi ako ma-ospital sa Pasko!" Said with a smile, it works.
- 8 Take all your medicines on schedule — party or no party.**
Set phone alarms. The celebration is not a holiday from your BP medicines, binders, or insulin. And never "fix" the morning-after headache with NSAIDs (mefenamic acid, ibuprofen) — they injure whatever kidney function you have left.

Protect Your Dialysis Schedule



TIMING PEARL

Timing is Everything.

A little planning today for a healthier tomorrow.

Good timing with your dialysis, meals, fluids, and rest can help you enjoy the holidays and protect your kidneys.



TIME IT RIGHT FOR BETTER DAYS



1. SCHEDULE YOUR DIALYSIS

Don't skip sessions.
Book early and confirm your schedule before the holidays.



2. PLAN YOUR MEALS

Eat a kidney-friendly meal before parties.
Choose wisely during celebrations.



3. MANAGE YOUR FLUIDS

Stick to your daily fluid allowance — even when it's tempting to indulge.



4. GET ENOUGH REST

Rest helps your body recover and keeps you strong for the celebrations ahead.



5. TAKE YOUR MEDICATIONS

Don't miss a dose.
Set reminders and bring your meds wherever you go.



ENJOY THE MOMENTS. PROTECT WHAT MATTERS.

Plan ahead. Stay on track.
Make this season wonderful for you and your loved ones.

Small steps today.
Stronger kidneys tomorrow.



You are not alone in your kidney journey.
Your care today is their tomorrow.



Every patient is different.
Talk to your nephrologist or dietitian for a plan that's right for you.



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- **By December 1** — check whether Dec 24, 25, 31, or Jan 1 lands on your session day; ask the unit for its holiday schedule early — good slots go fast.
- **Move sessions EARLIER, never later** — if your session falls on the holiday itself, request the day before, not the day after.
- **The smartest party trick** — book a morning slot on Dec 24 / Dec 31 and celebrate that evening — same food, far less danger.
- **Traveling to the province?** — book guest dialysis at the destination BEFORE booking the bus or flight.
- **Never trade a session for a party** — attend after your session, arrive late, leave early, or move the family celebration — your family would rather move the party than visit you in the ICU.

EMERGENCY

Warning Signs — Do NOT Wait for Your Next Session

During or after any celebration, any of these signs means go to the emergency room NOW — at midnight, on Christmas, whenever. High potassium can stop the heart with little warning, and the early symptoms are easy to dismiss as party fatigue.

- ! Chest heaviness or chest pain.
- ! **Palpitations** — racing, skipping, or irregular heartbeat.
- ! **Muscle weakness or heaviness** — of the arms and legs — a classic high-potassium sign.
- ! **Numbness or tingling** — around the lips and fingers.
- ! **Shortness of breath** — cannot lie flat, frothy cough — fluid overload.
- ! **Sudden swelling** — of face or legs with a big weight jump.
- ! **Confusion, extreme drowsiness** — or decreased alertness.
- ! **Hiccups that will not stop after star fruit** — an emergency even if you feel "okay".

Say this at the ER — exact words

"I am a dialysis patient (or: I have stage __ CKD). My last dialysis was on __. I ate a large amount of high-potassium food today. Please check my potassium and do an ECG now."

KIDNEY PATIENT — EMERGENCY CARD

Name: _____

Diagnosis: ☐ CKD stage __ ☐ Hemodialysis ☐ PD

Dialysis days: _____ Dry weight: _____ kg

Dialysis unit & phone: _____

Nephrologist: _____

Allergies: _____

IN EMERGENCY: check serum potassium + ECG immediately. Patient may need urgent dialysis.

Fill out in ink, cut along the border, and laminate. Keep one in your wallet and give one to a family member. An online fillable version is on the guide page.

Pre-Party Checklist

- ☐ Dialysis schedule for the holiday week confirmed — session moved EARLIER if needed
- ☐ Phosphate binders and all medicines in pocket or bag
- ☐ Ate a kidney-safe meal before leaving — not arriving hungry
- ☐ Fruit decision made: which one, how much, once
- ☐ Fluid budget set; small-cup strategy ready
- ☐ "No thank you" script practiced
- ☐ Nearest open ER on a holiday identified; unit phone number saved
- ☐ One family member briefed on the warning signs
- ☐ Weigh yourself the morning after — bring the number to your next session

For your family and hosts

Food is love — and the most loving thing you can do for a kidney patient is make safe eating easy: cook one plain grilled dish, serve sauces on the side, accept their "no" the first time, keep the fruit bowl out of grazing distance, and know the warning signs.

References & full guide

Foley RN et al., N Engl J Med 2011;365:1099-107 (long interdialytic interval)

Ettinger PO et al., Am Heart J 1978 (holiday heart) · Wakasugi M et al., J Ren Nutr 2023

KDOQI Clinical Practice Guideline for Nutrition in CKD: 2020 Update

Full interactive guide (EN · TL · CEB · KAP): williamriveromd.com/guides/surviving-fiestas-holidays-ckd.html

This companion is for general education and does not replace the advice of your own nephrologist and renal dietitian. "Holiday Kidney Syndrome" is a descriptive teaching term used in this practice, not an official diagnosis. © 2026 W. G. M. Rivero, MD — williamriveromd.com